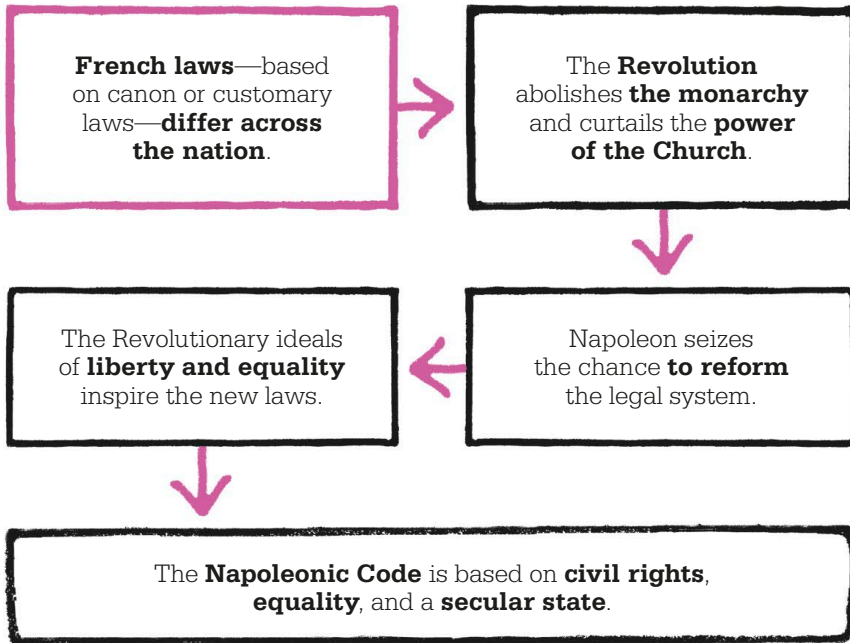


See also: The origins of canon law 42–47 ■ Magna Carta 66–71 ■ The US Constitution and Bill of Rights 110–117 ■ The Declaration of the Rights of Man 118–119



was built around key Revolutionary ideas—the principles of civil liberty (basic human rights and freedoms under the law), equality, and a secular state where people had the right to religious dissent. By making all (male) citizens equal before the law, it sought to end primogeniture (the eldest son's right to inherit property), hereditary nobility, and class privilege. It protected men's property rights, but women were legally subordinate to fathers or husbands. The Code divided civil law into property and family law and codified criminal and commercial law. A new freedom to form contracts without government interference was also included.

An enduring influence

The Napoleonic Code was highly influential. Countries under the control of France in 1804—including Belgium, Luxembourg, and parts of

Germany and Italy—all introduced it, as did a number of Latin American countries. Its influence is also evident in the law codes of some Middle Eastern nations. In many countries that adopted it, the Code, although updated and revised, is still the cornerstone of civil laws today. ■

“

My real glory is not the forty battles I won ...
What nothing will destroy, what will live forever, is my Civil Code.
Napoleon Bonaparte

”



Napoleon Bonaparte

Born in 1769 in Corsica, Napoleon was educated in France from the age of 9, later attending a military academy in Paris. He forged a successful military career, rising through the ranks and, in 1795, he played a major role in suppressing rebels opposed to the National Convention, the first government of the French Revolution. In 1799, however, he took advantage of the power vacuum to seize control in a coup d'état.

Napoleon crowned himself emperor in 1804 and launched a series of military campaigns to expand the French Empire, conquering swathes of continental Europe and ousting Spain as a colonial power in much of Latin America. In 1812, he was forced to abdicate after a disastrous invasion of Russia but returned to power in 1815. After defeat by the British at the Battle of Waterloo, Napoleon was exiled to the island of St. Helena, off the western coast of Africa, where he died in 1821. He left behind numerous letters, speeches, addresses, and proclamations to his troops, some of which were collected and published.